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Neighbourhood First: A Stable Periphery

Background: The Problem of Neighbours

In addition to the challenge of accelerating domestic development and thereby enhancing Indian power, one of the outstanding issues that India has had to confront is a challenging and sometimes volatile neighbourhood. India has five privileged relationships in its immediate periphery. For India, each of these countries is important it in own right. But each also has its own unique features and complexities. India's ties with all five of these neighbours have sometimes been fraught but, unlike relations with Pakistan or China, have been more cooperative than adversarial.

The first, Bhutan, initially opted for economic and political isolation in the 1940s and 1950s, a decision which India respected and indeed facilitated. The 1949 India–Bhutan Friendship Treaty, amended and renewed in 2007, involved India's support for Bhutan's security. [1] India has a standing mission in Bhutan to train and equip the Royal Bhutan Army (RBA), known as the Indian Military Training Team (IMTRAT). The RBA also sends trainees to the Indian Military Academy and National Defence Academy and Bhutan's diplomats have trained alongside Indian Foreign Service (IFS) officers. Bhutan's military forces also coordinate closely with the Indian Air Force for support and logistics. Additionally, Bhutan is also by far the largest recipient of Indian government grant assistance.

Although India signed a Treaty of Peace and Friendship with Nepal, and initially had similar defence arrangements to those with Bhutan, the security dimension of relations became diluted much earlier. Beginning in the 1950s, Nepal adopted a more independent foreign policy. In 1960, Nepal reached a border agreement with China and in 1969, Indian military forces